‘Who had heard of Maurya before that in the state,’ a local political leader pointed out. Yet, his appointment, first as state party chief, and later as one of the two deputy chief ministers in Yogi Adityanath’s government, reflected the BJP’s OBC push. Similarly, Swatantra Dev Singh, a Kurmi OBC leader from Mirzapur, Bundelkhand, was appointed the state unit chief in July 2019, after Yogi Adityanath, a Thakur, became chief minister in 2017.

Modi, OBCs and the BJP’s Caste Messaging

Crucially, Modi himself is OBC, classified in government records as a Modh Ghanchi, a caste of oil-pressers in Gujarat. Much has been made of the prime minister’s humble origins as a tea-seller. In terms of caste, the fact of his OBC status has been both explicit and implicit in the BJP’s political messaging, especially in the Hindi heartland. Modi’s caste was not always OBC. While Muslim Ghanchis in Gujarat were classified as OBCs in 1993, Hindu Modh Ghanchis were added to the list by the state government in 1994 and by the Union government in 1999.[34] These circulars turned Modi into an OBC leader at forty-nine, halfway into his political career, but well before he first won elected office in 2001 as Gujarat chief minister. Initially, Modi and the BJP did not make much of his OBC status, except when there was a controversy in 2014. The Congress’s then state leader Shaktisinh Gohil, current Rajya Sabha MP, accused Modi of being a ‘fake OBC’ in 2014 during the latter’s campaign for prime ministership.[35] That verbal skirmish on Modi’s OBC status passed below the national radar, since no major national Opposition leader repeated it. Modi himself chose not to respond to the diatribe, though his office issued a strong rebuttal. By 2019, though, the BJP’s OBC inroads were deep enough for the charge to be repeated by BSP chief Mayawati at the height of the national election campaign in 2019. She accused Modi of being a ‘zabardasti ka pichhda’ (pushed backward by force). It was telling that Mayawati chose to make the jibe at her first rally with SP’s Mulayam Singh Yadav in twenty-four years. Flanked by Yadav, she argued that Modi was not a backward caste person by birth,[36] comparing him with the SP leader, whom she called a ‘real leader’ of the Backwards.[37] It